



**KRISTU JAYANTI**  
(DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITY)  
Under Section 3 of UGC Act 1956  
A CMI INSTITUTION | BENGALURU | INDIA

## **General English II**

**TEXTS AND MEDIATED VOICES**  
**General English II (BCom, BBA)**

## 25GEN3T321: TEXTS AND MEDIATED VOICES

### 1. Course Description

|                                              |                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Semester: II                                 | Course Type: AEC                                                                                        |
| Course Credits: 3                            | Total Hours: 45                                                                                         |
| Cross cutting issue(s) addressed             | Human Values / Social Justice / Gender Rights / Professional Ethics / Environmental Sustainability/ SDG |
| Need(s) catered by the Course                | National / Global                                                                                       |
| Course offered to                            | BCom, BBA                                                                                               |
| Prerequisite / Concurrent Course(s) (if any) |                                                                                                         |

### 2. Course Objectives

- To develop students' ability to produce structured, clear, and effective academic and professional texts with attention to tone, purpose, and audience.
- To enable critical engagement with literary and media texts that explore identity, representation, and marginalised voices within Indian sociocultural contexts.
- To introduce students to the evolving role of artificial intelligence in communication, with emphasis on digital fluency, ethical considerations, and responsible use of emerging technologies.

### 3. Course Outcomes

- CLO1: compose various academic and professional documents—such as reports, emails, CVs, SOPs, and social media copy—using appropriate structure, language, and conventions.
- CLO2: analyze literary and media texts to interpret how language shapes identity, power structures, and social narratives, particularly from marginalised perspectives.
- CLO3: demonstrate informed and ethical use of digital tools and AI-based platforms for communication and content creation, with awareness of issues like bias, authorship, and data privacy.

### 4. Course Content

| Content                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Hours           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| <b>Unit 1: Writing for Academic and Professional Purposes</b><br><br><b>Themes:</b> Clarity, conciseness, coherence, and formal writing skills.<br><b>Key Topics:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>● Report Writing: Types and Structure; Informational and analytical reports, Minutes, and memo writing.</li><li>● Professional Email Communication; Business email etiquette, Cover Letter (Language and Tone).</li><li>● Curriculum Vitae (CV) Preparation: Effective use of keywords, formatting</li></ul> | <b>12 hours</b> |

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|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| <p>guidelines, and introduction to video resumes and ATS optimization.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Statement of Purpose (SOP)- Structure, Style and Content.</li> <li>• Copy Writing for social media: Storytelling as a tool for Advertisements- Platform specific language, Emotional Appeal, Hashtags.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                 |
| <p><b>Unit 2: Identity, and Representation in Texts</b></p> <p><b>Themes:</b> Language and power, Indian English narratives, Voices from the margins.</p> <p><b>Key Topics:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• “Non- Existent” by M. Senthamarai (Story).</li> <li>• “An Orphan’s Burial” by Thakazhi S Pillai (Story).</li> <li>• “The Mad” by K Satchidanandan (Poem).</li> <li>• “An Old Woman” by Arun Kolatkar (Poem).</li> <li>• “Her Story, My Story: Why I am Hopeful about Gender Justice” by Droupati Murmu President of India (Prose).</li> <li>• <i>Rammat Gammat</i> (Short Film by Ajitpal Singh) <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2OgWD2zyTf0">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2OgWD2zyTf0</a></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>16 hours</b> |
| <p><b>Unit 3: The Future of Language – AI, Ethics, and Digital Fluency</b></p> <p><b>Key Topics:</b></p> <p>Role of AI in Interpersonal and Social Communication</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• A brief introduction to prompting and tools like ChatGPT, Grammarly, and Perplexity).</li> <li>• “Be Polite to ChatGPT and Siri!- A Beginner’s Guide to AI” <a href="https://pods.ee/e/863477">https://pods.ee/e/863477</a></li> <li>• “All Watched over by Machines of Loving Grace” - Richard Braitigan (Poem).</li> </ul> <p>AI and Creativity- Brainstorming Tools, Text and Image Generation, Authorship and Originality.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• “The Future of Writing Is a Lot Like Hip-Hop”- Stephen Marche (Atlantic).</li> <li>• ChatGPT-generated poetry vs human-written poem.</li> </ul> <p>Ethics in AI: Strategies to detect Bias, Hallucinations, Privacy and Data Protection.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• “There Will Come Soft Rains” - Ray Bradbury</li> </ul> | <b>17 hours</b> |

## 5. Resources

### a) Reference Books

- Anderson, Paul V. *Technical Communication: A Reader-Centered Approach*. 8th ed., Cengage Learning, 2013.
- Bailey, Stephen. *Academic Writing: A Handbook for International Students*. 5th ed., Routledge, 2018.
- Floridi, Luciano. *Artificial Intelligence: A Philosophy of Technology*. Springer, 2019.
- Guffey, Mary Ellen, and Dana Loewy. *Business Communication: Process and Product*. 9th ed., Cengage Learning, 2018.
- Long, David, and Brian Magerko. "What Is AI Literacy? Competencies and Design Considerations." *Proceedings of the 2020 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 2020, pp. 1–16. ACM, <https://doi.org/10.1145/3313831.3376727>.
- Mehrotra, Arvind Krishna, editor. *An Illustrated History of Indian Literature in English*. Permanent Black, 2003.
- Murugan, Perumal, editor. *Black Coffee in a Coconut Shell: Caste as Lived Experience*. Edited by C. S. Lakshmi, SAGE Publications India, 2017.
- Swales, John M., and Christine B. Feak. *Academic Writing for Graduate Students: Essential Tasks and Skills*. 3rd ed., University of Michigan Press, 2012.

**b) Suggested Policies / Reports / Articles / Case Studies**

**c) Online Resources (websites, blogs, online videos, etc.)**

- <https://sahitya-akademi.gov.in>
- <http://www.languageinindia.com>
- <https://writingcenter.fas.harvard.edu>
- <https://owl.purdue.edu>

## **Unit 1: Writing for Academic and Professional Purposes**

### **1. Report Writing:**

The purpose of a report is often to present relevant information in an ordered way and to make carefully considered suggestions based on that information. Reports are typically a combination of fact and opinion, drawing on key facts and details to provide suggestions to the reader. Reports can also be used to offer an objective view of a situation, proposing alternatives for the reader to consider.

#### **Language**

- Think about the audience that the report is for – are you writing this report for one reader, or for a group of people such as the organisers of an event?
- The impression you want your reader to have of you – usually a report should be impersonal and relatively formal since you are writing to someone who is in charge. You would not normally use slang or contractions (such as don't or can't). It is usually best to avoid attempts at humour or sarcasm
- The purpose for the report – you may have been asked to make suggestions or recommendations in your report based on personal experience, or to offer an overview of a more complex situation. Try to include a range of topic related vocabulary used appropriately
- How to reassure your reader that your report is going to be useful – imagine if your report was full of emotive words and personal appeals based on your own viewpoint, your reader might not be convinced that you were offering them an objective and accurate evaluation. For your report to be effective you will need to sound calm and polite.

#### **Types of Reports**

Different Types of Reports serve various purposes, and understanding their distinctions is crucial for effective communication in academic, professional, and organisational settings. Here, we'll explore four common types of Reports:

##### **1) Routine Reports**

Routine Reports are regular updates on ongoing activities, often within an organisation. These Reports provide concise information about daily or periodic operations, helping stakeholders stay informed and make informed decisions.

## 2) Special Reports

Special Reports are more in-depth and are created for specific purposes, such as investigating a particular issue or analysing a unique situation. These Reports require extensive research, Critical Thinking, and a comprehensive presentation of findings. They are often used to address complex problems or make critical decisions.

For instance, a company might commission a Special Report to evaluate the impact of a new product launch.

## 3) Formal Reports

Formal Reports are comprehensive and meticulously structured documents characterised by a standardised format. They usually include a title page, table of contents, executive summary, methodology, findings, discussion, recommendations, and conclusion. Writing Research Proposal is a common type of Formal Report. Formal Reports are common in academic and corporate environments, as well as in government and research institutions.

## 4) Informal Reports

Informal Reports are less structured and often used for internal communication within an organisation. They are generally shorter and more straightforward than Formal Reports, emphasising brevity and efficiency.

Memos, email updates, and short Progress Reports are common examples of informal Reports. They serve to share information quickly, often within a department or among team members. Informal Reports are valuable for everyday communication, problem-solving, and decision-making within an organisation, and they do not require the extensive structure and formality of Formal Reports.

### **What is the structure of a report?**

The report format depends on the report type and the assignment requirements. While reports can use their own structure, most follow this basic template:

**Executive summary:** Like an abstract in an academic paper, an executive summary is a standalone section that summarises the key findings of your report, allowing readers to understand what to expect. Executive summaries are primarily used for official reports, and less so for school reports.

**Introduction:** The introduction sets up the body of the report and explains the overall topic you're about to discuss. It includes your thesis statement and any need-to-know background information before you discuss your findings.

**Body:** The body of the report presents your significant discoveries, organised into headings and subheadings. The body comprises the majority of the report, whereas the introduction and conclusion are typically brief, each consisting of just a few paragraphs.

**Conclusion:** In the conclusion, you bring together all the information in your report and come to a definitive interpretation or judgment. It's also usually where the author adds their own opinions or inferences.

### **Analytical report**

An analytical report is a written document that is used by businesses to make decisions. It achieves three main goals: assesses possible opportunities, identifies solutions to problems, or supports decision-making.

#### **What are two examples of analytical reports?**

Two examples of analytical reports would be a report on investigating business opportunities (Ex: advantages and disadvantages of taking a specific course of action whether investing in a company, buying a competitor, or investigating a new product venture) and report on problem solving (Ex: solve corporate issues and offer a specific solution through troubleshooting analysis). An example of investigating a business opportunity would be if a company did a report on expanding their product into an additional market. An example of a problem-solving report would be if a company did a report on why a product continues to break.

### **Informational Reports:**

An informational report is a factual document which provides information in an organized and objective way, without analysis or recommendations. Basically, it's all about reporting facts. So, it often includes data, details, feedback, or any other type of information about any topic or event. One major element of informational reports is that they don't contain any arguments. They are always objective and maintain a neutral position that is free from personal views or of bias.

## **2. Meeting Minutes**

Meeting minutes are the written record of what was discussed and decided during a meeting. They typically include the date and time of the meeting, a list of attendees, a summary of the topics discussed, decisions made, action items assigned, and the time of adjournment.

Minutes are essential for providing an official account of the meeting, ensuring accountability, and helping attendees recall important details. They are usually prepared by a designated person, such as a secretary or administrative assistant, and are approved at the subsequent meeting.

Meeting minutes usually include the following:

- Date and time of the meeting
- Names of the meeting participants and those unable to attend
- Acceptance or corrections/amendments to previous meeting minutes
- Decisions made about each agenda item, for Example:
  - Actions taken or agreed to be taken
  - Next steps
  - Voting outcomes – e.g., (if necessary, details regarding who made motions; who seconded and approved or via show of hands, etc.)
  - Motions taken or rejected
  - Items to be held over
  - New business
  - Next meeting date and time

## **3. Memos:**

A memo, short for *memorandum*, is a way to inform a group of people about a specific problem, solution, or event. A memo should be brief, straightforward, and easy to read. It informs recipients and provides an action plan with specific next steps.

### **What is the purpose of a memo?**

Memos are designed for official internal communications of a business or organization. They are often sent to the entire organization but are also useful for informing a single department, team, or smaller group of people. Memos disperse necessary information using a simple, easy-to-follow format.

### **When to write a memo?**

You should write a memorandum when you need to relay official business items efficiently. The aim of your memo should be to inform, bring attention to a problem, or answer a question. However, a memorandum can occasionally include a call to action or a persuasive element. Here are some instances when a high-quality memo might be useful:



- Informing employees about company policy or process changes
- Providing an update on key projects or goals
- Making an announcement about the company, such as an employee promotion or new hire
- Reminding employees about a task that needs to be completed
- Making a request of all employees (perhaps related to an occurrence when something went wrong)
- Communicating a message that employees will refer to more than once, such as a detailed proposal or recommendation

### **How to format a memo?**

If you are sending a memo via email, it should be formatted as a PDF. This retains the style you've applied to the document. Traditionally, memos use a 12-point font for the body and a 14- to 16-point font for the headings. Keep the font and design simple.

A memo should include the following:

- Heading
  - To
  - From
  - Date
  - Subject
- Opening statement
- Context
- Call to action and task statement
- Discussion
- Closing

You also have the option to include attachments to support the message you are conveying in your memo. If your memo is more than one page, you should have a summary to wrap up your points.

### **Difference between minutes and memorandum**

**Minutes:** An official record of the proceedings at a meeting of an organization. It is generally accepted as an official document, and, as such, can be used in eventual disputes arising from matters discussed therein.

**Memorandum:** Generally, memorandum, which is frequently referred to colloquially as "memo", is a record prepared on the basis of what has been orally discussed. As such, it is sometimes used instead of minutes, but it does not imply any officialdom.

## **4. Email Writing**

In today's fast-paced professional world, email remains a fundamental tool for communication. However, with the ease and convenience of email comes the responsibility to communicate clearly and respectfully.

Mastering email etiquette is not just about avoiding embarrassing mistakes; it's about fostering positive relationships, maintaining professionalism, and ensuring that your message is received as intended.

### **What is Email Etiquette?**

Email etiquette refers to the set of rules and guidelines that govern how to compose and respond to emails in a professional setting. It's about ensuring your emails are clear, concise, and respectful, reflecting the professionalism expected in the workplace.

### **Importance of Email Etiquette in Professional Communication**

Mastering email etiquette is essential in today's digital world, where much of our communication takes place online. Whether you're interacting with colleagues, clients, or superiors, following proper email etiquette can significantly influence how others perceive you.

Poor email habits, such as unclear subject lines, improper salutations, or lack of follow-up, can lead to misunderstandings, delays, and even damage your professional reputation.

### **Rules of Formal Email Writing**

In the professional world, emails are a primary mode of communication. Whether you're sending a quick update, a meeting request, or a detailed report, how you craft your email speaks volumes about your professionalism.

Mastering the rules of writing formal emails is essential to ensure your messages are clear, effective, and well-received. The key elements to consider when writing formal emails are below:

#### **1. Subject Line and Its Significance**

The subject line is the first thing your recipient sees, making it one of the most crucial parts of your email.

A well-crafted subject line should be clear, concise, and informative. It should give the reader a snapshot of the email's content without being overly vague or too detailed.

Example of a Good Subject Line:

- "Meeting Request: End semester Examination Discussion"
- "Update: New Assignment Timelines"

Tips:

- Keep it brief (6-10 words is ideal).
- Use keywords that reflect the email's content.

- Avoid using all caps, exclamation points, or vague phrases like "Important" or "URGENT" without context.

## **2. Appropriate Salutations and Closings**

Choosing the right salutation and closing sets the tone for your email. The formality of your greeting and sign-off should align with your relationship with the recipient and the context of the email.

Common Salutations:

- Formal: "Dear [Title] [Last Name],"
- Semi-Formal: "Hello [First Name],"
- Less Formal: "Hi [First Name],"

Common Closings:

- Formal: "Sincerely," "Best regards,"
- Semi-Formal: "Best," "Kind regards,"
- Less Formal: "Cheers," "Thanks,"

When in doubt, err on the side of formality, especially when emailing someone for the first time or in a high-stakes situation.

## **3. Structure and Formatting of a Professional Email**

A well-structured email is easy to read and navigate. Proper formatting ensures that your key points are clear and not lost in dense text.

Key Elements:

- Opening Line: Start with a polite greeting and a brief introduction if necessary. If you're following up on a previous conversation, reference it here.
- Body: Break your content into short paragraphs, each covering a single point or question. Use bullet points or numbered lists for clarity if you have multiple points.
- Closing Line: End with a courteous remark, such as "I look forward to your response" or "Please let me know if you need any further information."

Formatting Tips:

- Use a professional font (e.g., Arial, Calibri) at a standard size (10-12 pt).
- Avoid excessive use of bold or italics; reserve them for emphasis.
- Ensure there's sufficient white space to avoid overwhelming the reader.

## **4. Language and Tone**

The language and tone of your email should reflect professionalism and respect. Formal emails require clear, precise language free of slang or overly casual expressions.

Tips for Professional Language:

- Be concise: Avoid long-winded explanations. Stick to the point and be specific.

- Use proper grammar and punctuation: Errors can undermine your credibility.
- Maintain a respectful tone: Even if addressing a conflict or disagreement, stay courteous and professional.

Example of a Formal Tone:

- "I would like to request a meeting to discuss the upcoming project deadlines. Please let me know a convenient time for you."

Example of an Informal Tone (to be avoided in formal emails):

- "Hey, can we catch up on the deadlines? Let me know when you're free."

By following these rules, you can ensure that your formal emails convey your message clearly and leave a positive impression on your recipients.

Remember, in the world of professional communication, how you say something is often just as important as what you say.

## **Email Etiquette Examples**

Here are some examples of email etiquette to keep in mind for professional communication:

### **1. Subject Line**

- Effective: "Project Deadline Extension Request"
- Ineffective: "Help?"

### **2. Greeting**

- Formal: "Dear Dr. Smith,"
- Informal (if appropriate): "Hi Alex,"

### **3. Body**

- Clear and Concise: "I am writing to inquire about the status of the Q3 financial report. Could you provide an update by the end of the day?"
- Overly Detailed: "I wanted to touch base about the quarterly financial statements. As you know, these reports are quite comprehensive and include various metrics and analyses. I'm particularly interested in the section regarding revenue projections, so please let me know when you can provide the information."

### **4. Tone**

- Professional: "Thank you for your assistance with this matter. I appreciate your prompt attention."
- Too Casual: "Thanks a bunch for helping out!"

### **5. Closing**

- Formal: "Best regards, [Your Name]"

- Informal: “Cheers, [Your Name]”

## **6. Signature**

- Complete: “John Doe | Senior Marketing Manager | XYZ Corp | (555) 123-4567 | john.doe@xyzcorp.com”
- Incomplete: “John Doe”

## **7. Attachments**

- Effective: “Please find the report attached for your review. Let me know if you have any questions.”
- Ineffective: “Attached is the report. Thanks.”

## **8. Response Time**

- Timely: “Thank you for your email. I will get back to you with a detailed response by tomorrow.”
- Delayed: “I just saw your email. I’ll reply when I can.”

## **9. Follow-Up**

- Polite: “I’m following up on my previous email regarding the project update. Could you please provide an update at your earliest convenience?”
- Pushy: “I need a response now. It’s been days!”

## **10. Clarity**

- Effective: “Could you please confirm your availability for the meeting on Tuesday at 10 AM?”
- Confusing: “Can you do the thing? Let me know.”

Maintaining clear, respectful, and well-structured communication in your emails helps ensure that your messages are received positively and understood correctly.

## **5. Cover letter**

A cover letter is a one-page business letter that you submit when applying to a job, along with your resume. As a piece of persuasive writing, your cover letter will aim to convey to the employer why you're a great candidate for the role.

### **How to write a cover letter?**

A cover letter introduces you to an employer and asks them to think about your application.

It's a short letter, usually 3 to 5 paragraphs long.

### **When to include a cover letter?**

You should always include a cover letter when you apply for a job using a CV.

You can write it as an email if you're applying online, or print a copy to accompany a paper application.

### **Research**

When writing a cover letter, let the employer know you're keen by showing that you've researched the company. Learn more about what they do through:

- their website
- recent news articles
- talking to people you know who work there

### **Send it to the right person.**

It's essential to address your cover letter to a specific person by name. Check you have the details of the person you need to send it to.

You'll need their name and preferred title. For Example, 'Dr', 'Mr', 'Mrs', 'Ms', and their job title.

### **If you do not know their name**

If the job advert does not include a name, you can check the company website. Try to find the details of the department head, head of human resources, or a recruitment manager.

If you still cannot find a name, you can start your letter with 'Dear Sir or Madam'.

### **Introduction**

Introduce yourself and explain how you found the advertised job. You can mention the job title and reference number, if applicable.

If you're asking about any job openings and not applying to a vacancy, tell them what sort of job you're looking for. Let the employer see how keen you are to work for them.

Show you're right fit for the job

Highlight the skills and experience you have that match what the employer is looking for.

Convince them that you're enthusiastic about working for them. Let them know you share their work values, culture and style.

### **Give extra information**

If you have gaps in your employment history, you could talk about the skills you gained while you were out of work.

### **Ending your cover letter**

Thank the employer for considering your application. Let them know that they can obtain more details from your CV, and inform them that you look forward to hearing from them.

Let them know how they can best contact you. Ensure that your contact details are accurate on both your cover letter and CV.

### **Yours sincerely or yours faithfully**

If you know the name of the person you're writing to, you should end the letter with 'Yours sincerely'.

If you've addressed the letter 'Dear Sir or Madam', you should end the letter with 'Yours faithfully'.

### **Tips for writing a cover letter**

When writing your cover letter, remember to:

- Write a new one for every job you apply for and make sure it's tailored to the company and the specific role
- Use the same font and size as you do for your CV, so it looks consistent
- Make sure the company name and recruiter's details are correct
- Use the right language and tone: keep it professional and match the keywords used by the employer in their job advert
- show you've done your research into the job and the company
- Highlight your most relevant skills and experience to stand out from other applicants
- Back up any statements you make with facts
- Double-check spelling and grammar before you send it
- Keep a copy of your cover letter as they may ask you about it in an interview

## 6. What is a Curriculum Vitae (CV)?

A CV is a detailed professional document highlighting a person's work experience and accomplishments. Employers often require a CV when considering job applications. This document shares an overview of your career history, education, relevant skills, awards and honours, scholarships, grants, research, projects and publications. You may also include coursework, fieldwork, professional references and interests relevant to your industry. Many candidates also include a personal statement or profile to highlight their core attributes and provide employers with a more comprehensive view of their qualifications and personality. Writing an effective curriculum vitae can be valuable for your job search.

### What To Include In A CV?

You are required to include the following sections as per the best CV format:

**Contact information:** Include your full name, address, phone number and email address.

**CV objective or personal statement:** A personal statement in a CV is a brief summary that highlights your skills, experiences and career goals. It introduces you to the recruiters and showcases your suitability for the job.

**Academic history:** Your education section can include details of your complete academic history, such as the name of the institution, the degree earned, your graduation year and any relevant coursework. This allows potential employers who review your curriculum vitae to verify your academic background easily and assess your qualifications. A well-structured professional CV with your academic history enhances credibility and supports a successful job application.

**Work experience:** This CV section can include the organisation where you worked, the job title, the dates you were employed and a summary of your knowledge and professional experience.

**Qualifications and skills:** Including relevant skills is important to impress potential employers. You can list a combination of hard and soft skills you have developed throughout your career.

**Awards and honours:** For each award, consider adding the name, year received, the organisation that gave you the award and any pertinent details (such as how often it is presented).

**Publications and presentations:** For publications, you can provide a full citation including your co-authors, date, summary, volume, page and date of issue (DOI) number. For presentations, provide the title, date and venue where you presented.

**Professional associations:** List the organisation's name, location or chapter, and the dates of active membership.

**Grants and scholarships:** Your curriculum vitae can benefit from mentioning any grants or scholarships you may have received. You can provide the name of the grant or scholarship, the date when it was awarded and the institution that provided the award.

**Licenses and certifications:** You can also include the name of the license or certificate, the date you earned it and the institution that awarded it.



### **Three Types Of CV Format**

All three types of CVs are required to include the above information. The primary difference between formats is the order of these elements:

#### **1. Chronological**

Also known as the reverse chronological resume, the chronological resume format is one of the more widely used professional CV formats. In a chronological CV, you present your academic history and professional experience directly after your contact information. This format emphasises your work history and educational background, making it well-suited for job seekers with a steady and consistent career path. It is also highly compatible with applicant tracking systems, improving visibility with recruiters and hiring managers.

A chronological CV typically includes the following sections:

- Contact information
- Personal statement
- Academic history
- Work experience
- Qualifications and skills
- Awards and honours
- Publications and presentations
- Grants and scholarships
- Licenses and certifications
- Professional associations

A chronological CV is best if you have consistent employment within the same industry and your work experience displays advancement within your field.

#### **2. Functional**

This CV format places greater emphasis on your relevant skills, awards and honours, and overall qualifications. If you are preparing a functional CV, dedicate a section for your skills and place it prominently just below your contact information. In this structure, you dedicate more space to qualifications, soft skills, certifications and achievements, and less space to your professional experience. This format is particularly useful for job seekers who are recent graduates, have gaps in their work history or are transitioning into a new field. The following CV sections are typically included:

- Contact information

- Qualifications and skills
- Awards and honours
- Academic history
- Professional experience
- Publications and presentations
- Grants and scholarships
- Licenses and certifications
- Professional associations

This is an ideal choice for those entering the job market, changing career paths, or looking for a structure that focuses on relevant work experience and transferable strengths.

### **3. Combination**

This CV type is a hybrid of the reverse chronological and functional CV formats, offering balanced space to highlight your professional experience, academic history, relevant skills and accomplishments. The CV sections you choose to place first will depend on your job title, career goals and what you find most relevant to the job description. For instance, if you are applying for a teaching role at a university and have spent the past ten years as an educator, you can begin your curriculum vitae with your work experience section. This format is well-suited for job seekers who want to showcase both a strong work history and a targeted skills section.

### **5 tips on how the best ways to use Keywords in a CV**

#### **1. Pick out keywords from the job description**

The best place to look for keywords for each role is to look at the job description. Pay attention to the list of responsibilities and desired candidate points outlined. Also look at any specifics to that role that you can relate to.

E.g. if a role is in the commercial real estate sector and you've had five years' experience in this field, state it.

#### **2. Mention the skills, specialisms and qualifications you have relating to the role higher up**

Your personal statement or introduction is the first thing scanned for keywords, both by an ATS and a hiring manager. Be sure to mention key related specialisms, qualifications or skills for the role here.

#### **3. Don't over-use keywords**

There's a term for it: 'Keyword Stuffing'. It may be tempting to repeat the same keywords

everywhere and anywhere thinking you can outsmart the bots- please don't. It makes your CV look poor if phrases are repeated and become out of context for the sake of using a word as often as possible.

4. Make sure your CV still reads well for the end user

Drawing on the last point, you might get past an ATS by 'keyword stuffing', but the recruiter/Hiring Manager will simply put aside your CV if it reads poorly. Remember the ultimate end-user you're targeting.

5. Use a free Keyword-check tool

You'll find plenty of free platforms for checking CV keywords and see how you would rank in your sector. A few to note are Resume Worded, Jobscan and CV Scan.

## **What is a video resume?**

A video resume is pretty self-explanatory: it is your resume in video form.

The benefits of submitting a video resume include:

- Standing out from other applicants
- Showing your creative side
- Sharing a bit of your personality
- Providing hiring managers with a face instead of just a name

Ideally, a video resume will supplement all your other efforts. That's why we recommend sending in your resume and cover letter the traditional way. Then, include a link to your video resume in the online application.

Other options include locating the email address of the hiring manager or sending them a message on LinkedIn.

Preparing a script for your video resume

- It's important to prepare exactly what you want to share before you jump on camera. You don't want to "wing it" when it comes to creating your video resume.
- Choose some of the most important aspects of your resume to highlight on camera. Measurable results are especially important.
- Rehearse your script a few times. You want to sound like you are having a conversation with the hiring manager. The less you sound as if you are reading something off of paper, the better.

## What is an ATS Resume?

An ATS resume refers to a resume which follows a strategic structure that increases its probability of getting shortlisted by ATS software. The ATS scans and collects resumes before ranking them per their eligibility to meet the organisation's recruiting requirements. They act as electronic filters, especially when the volume of resumes is high. These systems reduce the workload of hiring managers by selecting resumes that are likely to be a good fit for the company.

These systems parse through text within a resume and import valuable information into a profile. After analysing the collected data, the ATS can pass the resume to the next stage of screening or reject it. That is why it is important to choose a resume template that helps you use relevant keywords and make it compliant with the ATS software.

### How To Write An ATS Resume

#### 1. Choose an appropriate template

A resume is your chance to create a positive first impression and improve your chances of getting shortlisted for the job. Focus on the resume content and layout, as an ATS may not read images, charts and other graphics. The layout you select may influence the content that the ATS reads and forwards to your potential employer. Select a template that looks professional, uses minimal colours and limits graphics.

#### 2. Define the sections of your resume

ATS-friendly resumes follow a structure and layout that favours the system. It enables the software to scan the document and improve its chances of selection. Many of these tracking systems may not scan items within the header and footer of the page. Ensure vital details such as your contact number and email are within the other areas of the resume template. Here are a few sections vital to a resume:

**Heading:** Add your name and job title in this section. Choose a simple and bold font that looks professional.

**Professional summary:** Provide a gist of your background, objective and skills in two or three sentences and modify it according to the job description. You may also include your contact details and highlight them appropriately for the system to read them.

**Education or experience:** Highlight your education and then experience or vice versa, depending on your level of expertise and relevancy to the position. Focus on the keywords you choose and be specific in the details you share, such as learning experience, outcome, role and functions.

**Skills:** Highlight relevant skills according to the job requirement and categorise them depending on your profession, like interpersonal skills or technical skills. Use this as an opportunity to add relevant keywords to your resume and optimise it for the software.

#### Use keyword optimisation

When an employer creates a job opening using ATS software, they feed specific keywords important to the job role. These are often a part of the job description and may act as your cue to include them in your resume. The system may overlook resumes without job-specific keywords, and these resumes may not reach the hiring managers. Look for industry-specific and role-specific terms that may occur multiple times in the job description. Ensure you include these keywords in your resume without over-using them. It is vital that these

keywords come organically to your resume and do not look forced.

**Use specific details**

Add specific details about your previous role and duties that make you suitable for the role. Even if you apply within the same field, the employer requirements for a job role may differ. Ensure to read and understand the job description and add the essential details. Keep the points brief while using job-appropriate keywords.

**Save the file in an appropriate format.**

Different application tracking software may accept different file formats. A widely accepted file format is PDF, which allows you to save a file without compromising its content and format. Make sure to check the accepted file format before you submit your application. Some tracking software may require you to submit the resume in a .doc or .docx format. Create a template that allows you to easily change file formats without compromising document integrity.

## 7. How to Start a Statement of Purpose?

Once you are drafting your statement of purpose, you have to be careful with what you write. To give you more confidence and help you write an outstanding essay follow these SOP tips for academic writing-

### Steps for Writing a Statement of Purpose

#### Step 1: Think

Highlight key achievements, setbacks, and growth

Identify why you're passionate about your chosen field of study

Define short/long-term goals and how this course helps achieve them

#### Step 2: Research

Explore course structure, faculty, and university missions and values

Understand how your goals align with the program

Justify briefly any academic shifts (e.g., changing your field)

#### Step 3: Draft

Start with a strong introduction about your motivation

Follow a logical structure: past, present, future

Use precise language and keep it authentic and personal

#### Step 4: Review

Revisit your checklist to ensure all points are covered

Remove irrelevant or repetitive content

Get feedback from a trusted friend or mentor

## Dos & Don'ts to Write a Powerful and Convincing SOP

In a strong and compelling Statement of Purpose, each point is related to the next by reason and logic. Check out the dos and don'ts while writing a statement of purpose-

| Dos on a Statement of Purpose                                   | Don'ts on a Statement of Purpose                        |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Ensure SOP is written in 1st person                             | Do not start with personal pronouns, conjunctions       |
| Use a chronological order of writing as suggested in the format | Do not write in the reverse order                       |
| Share goals, motivations and reasons to study                   | Do not share personal information and family background |

|                                                              |                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Use bold or single inverted commas                           | Do not use boxes or any other stylistic elements                             |
| Use anecdotes to support goals or reasons to study           | Never use quotes/song/poem/lines to start or end SOP (because of plag issue) |
| Draft and curate SOP on your own or use SOP writing services | Do not use AI to write your SOP                                              |

## **8. Copy Writing for Social Media:**

### **1. Storytelling as a Tool for Advertisements**

Why Storytelling Works

Stories create attention and emotional involvement

Audiences remember characters, conflicts, and resolutions

Makes a product feel relatable, human, and desirable

Elements of Storytelling

Character

The audience should identify with someone: user, customer, or brand ambassador.

Conflict / Problem

Show the issue or need: lack of time, need for style, stress, etc.

Resolution

The product/service becomes the solution.

Transformation

After using the product, life becomes better, easier, happier.

Storytelling Models

Before → After → Bridge

Before: show the problem

After: show the improved life

Bridge: introduce product

### **2. Platform-Specific Language**

Each platform has different audience expectations and content styles.

#### **Facebook**

Conversational, friendly

Longer posts allowed

Visuals + links

Use call-to-action: “Learn more”, “Shop now”

#### **Instagram**

Highly visual: photos, reels, carousels

Minimal text + strong emotional statement

Informal, stylish, trendy language

Hashtags are very important

#### **Twitter / X**

Short, punchy, witty

Focus on headlines, opinions, news, trends

Real-time conversation

Use 1–2 strong hashtags



## **LinkedIn**

Professional tone  
Focus on credibility, expertise, success stories  
Use facts, statistics, career growth  
Avoid slang

## **YouTube**

Storytelling in video  
Captions matter  
Build community via comments  
CTA: Subscribe, Watch next, Link in description

## **3. Emotional Appeal**

Emotions drive engagement and purchasing.  
Types of Appeals  
Happiness → positivity, joy, humour  
Fear of missing out (FOMO) → urgency, scarcity  
Trust & safety → credible, reliable  
Belonging → community, identity  
Inspiration → success, motivation  
Nostalgia → childhood, memories

How to Create Emotional Appeal?  
Use strong images  
Focus on benefits, not features  
Show real people  
Use personal stories and feedback  
Power Words  
Limited time  
Exclusive

## **4. Hashtags**

Purpose  
Increase visibility  
Reach broader audiences  
Connect to trends and communities

Types  
Brand hashtags  
#Nike #ShareACoke

Campaign hashtags  
#JustDoIt #MyCalmPlace

Trending hashtags

#MondayMotivation #ThrowbackThursday

Niche / Industry hashtags

#FitnessTips #TravelPhotography

Best Practices

Use 3–7 on Instagram

Use 1–2 on Twitter

Keep them relevant

Avoid overly generic tags like #love #happy

Hashtag Strategy

Mix:

Broad (#fashion)

Specific (#summeroutfit)

Local (#BengaluruStyle)

## Unit 2: Identity, and Representation in Texts

### THE MAD- K. Satchidanandan

The mad have no caste  
or religion. They transcend  
gender, live outside  
ideologies. We do not deserve  
their innocence.

Their language is not of dreams  
but of another reality. Their love  
is moonlight. It overflows  
on the full-moon day.

Looking up they see  
gods we have never heard of. They are  
shaking their wings when  
we fancy they are  
shrugging their shoulders. They hold  
that even flies have souls  
and the green god of grasshoppers  
leaps up on thin legs.

At times they see trees bleed, hear  
lions roaring from the streets. At times  
they watch Heaven gleaming  
in a kitten's eyes, just as  
we do. But they alone can hear  
ants sing in a chorus.

While patting the air  
they are taming a cyclone  
over the Mediterranean. With  
their heavy tread, they stop  
a volcano from erupting.

They have another measure  
of time. Our century is  
their second. Twenty seconds,  
and they reach Christ; six more,  
they are with the Buddha.

In a single day, they reach

the big bang at the beginning.

They go on walking restless, for  
their earth is boiling still.

The mad are not  
mad like us.

## **An Old Woman- Arun Kolatkar**

An old woman grabs  
hold of your sleeve  
and tags along.

She wants a fifty paise coin.  
She says she will take you  
to the horseshoe shrine.

You've seen it already.  
She hobbles along anyway  
and tightens her grip on your shirt

She won't let you go.  
You know how old women are.  
They stick to you like a burr.

You turn around and face her  
with an air of finality.  
You want to end the farce.

When you hear her say,  
'What else can an old woman do  
on hills as wretched as these?'

You look right at the sky.  
Clear through the bullet holes  
she has for her eyes.

And as you look on,  
the cracks that begin around her eyes  
spread beyond her skin.

And the hills crack.  
And the temples crack.  
And the sky falls

With a plate-glass clatter  
Around the shatterproof crone  
who stands alone

And you are reduced  
to so much small change  
in her hand.

## **An Orphan's Burial**

### **Thakazhi S Pillai**

And thus Makkar died. He had crawled his way to the hospital to die. During this final journey, he had been to many a bungalow on the way. Not to die there. But to get himself some gruel, a piece of cloth, or for shelter till the rains stopped. But they had shooed him away. And you can't blame them. What a bother it is to have an unclaimed corpse of an orphan in your compound!

Everyone in town knew Makkar. He had been around since he was five. And he had been begging right from that age: a handful of rice, an old rag. But as a beggar he was a miserable failure; he could never earn the sympathy of a single soul. If at all he had managed to get himself some alms, it was not because he could evoke goodness in you, but because you tended to try and rid yourselves of what was considered a pest, a stink, a hideous sight. But Makkar lived on. Yes, he lived on, unleashing an assault on you, eliciting a certain tax from you. As Habeeb Saheb, after a sumptuous lunch, retired to his first-floor bedroom and, holding the temporary break in his sensual pleasure, would invariably send down his wife to hand something over to Makkar and drive him away. As the familiar stink spread in the beautiful home gardens, devouring the fragrance of the flowers, the Sahebs would dig into their pockets for small change. When little kids stuffed themselves with sweet indulgences and insisted on more, the mothers would try to frighten them by saying, 'Makkar is coming!' And the kids would plug their noses and struggle to keep themselves from throwing up. And whenever anyone set out on a good job, Makkar would be the first one to be met on the way.

Makkar spent the thirty-five years of his life thus, eating cooked rice and wearing old rags. Meanwhile, there were a couple of occasions when he went about covering himself with a dirty cloth that was not stitched to size. And then he smelt of a decomposed corpse. It was heard that he had dug up a few graves in the cemetery attached to a local mosque.

All of a sudden Makkar had a bout of diarrhoea. And he collapsed. He was not even allowed to lie on the wayside let alone at the gates of bungalows. So he crawled his way to the hospital. In the process he had lost the rag tied round his waist. It was in fact a piece of cloth earlier used as a corpse's winding sheet.

As Makkar was removed to the mortuary, the piece of cloth he had received from the hospital was filched by the scavenger. Thus, again, Makkar was completely naked.

There were four deaths at the hospital that day. Three of the corpses were taken to the cremation grounds. Only Makkar was left there. Wasn't he rotten enough? Did he have to rot further in death?

In the afternoon a few Muslim elders came in with a santuq (coffin). To take him away; to give him a decent burial. They were reluctant to give anything to Makkar when he was alive.

He had to take things from them. Now that he was dead they were prepared to give him something. After all, it was good riddance!

They took him to a Muslim house nearby. Moideen, an important person in the locality, gave him a traditional bath using herbs and other perfumes. Makkar was given a fine shirt and a fresh mundu. Thus Makkar, dead, possessed a length of fine muslin cloth. Yes, it was Makkar the beggar, who lay there on the fresh soft cloth, soaked in attar and rose water! No Qatib or priest had ever bothered about the spiritual upliftment of Makkar when he was alive. Now that he was dead, the town Qatib chanted holy verses into his ears closed for ever.

Makkar's body was taken to the graveyard beside the mosque in a decorated santuq. All the important persons in the locality took part in the funeral procession, chanting dikr and praying for the departed soul. Through the windows of the sprawling bungalows beautiful women looked out at Makkar who had found salvation from life's hardship and had merged into everlasting peace. And their ruby lips moved with the holy prayer la ilah illallah. Thus Makkar, dead, became the public property of Islam.

The fact that there was no one to claim him when he was alive – perhaps it was because he was sullied with life. In which case, why couldn't all beggars among the Muslims strive toward liberation from that blemish? Then there would be folks to claim them. At the mosque the grave was ready. And Makkar, enshrouded in twenty-one cubits of fresh white cloth, was lowered into the grave. The piece of cloth that covered his face was removed. They turned his face in the direction of the holy land from where, 1400 years ago, the everlasting message of universal brotherhood had emanated. Perhaps the Holy Prophet whom the entire humankind must claim as their own, should be weeping, seeing how his message of brotherhood, aimed at the deepest recesses of the breathing human heart, had ended up as part of a mere funeral rite leading to the freezing cold of the grave. As the grave was covered over with a wooden plank, Rahim Saheb, Habeeb Saheb and others threw in handfuls of earth. "Yet another sign of brotherhood!"



## **Non-Existent**

### **M. Senthamarai**

During school days I did not know much about caste. My mother would get up in the morning and finish her household work and send me to school with the advice: 'Don't roam around with all and sundry. Sit with our people. Make them your friends. Don't mix with others.' I used to nod my head in agreement to whatever she said and leave for school. But I used to beat up someone or the other in school every day. That girl's father would come and complain to my father. My father would come home and scold me, 'Why do you beat others? You invite trouble unnecessarily.' I would not respond and would remain quiet with tears flowing. 'And now, all this drama and tears,' he would grumble.

When I was in fifth standard, there were only six girls in my class. All of us used to sit and eat together at lunch time. I always took curd rice with me for lunch. The others brought whatever was made in their homes. We used to share one another's food. One day I gave mine to a girl of another caste and ate hers.

At home my parents would normally ask me what lessons were taught at school and my father would ask me to show him my notebooks. He would then proceed to teach me. Whenever I lost interest I would make excuses, saying that my neck ached and that I was not able to sit long and study. Or I would say I was hungry. I always had some excuse handy and then I would go off to play. But I had the habit of telling them all about what happened in school every day. So on the day that I ate the other girl's food I told them that I had exchanged food with Valarmathi and eaten what she had brought.

"What! Valarmathi's food? She is a low caste girl. Why did you eat her food? Instead of eating what I gave you, why did you eat hers?" my mother said and hit me with a stick. I wondered why she was beating me for eating Valarmathi's food, considering she had never beaten me when I had told her on other occasions about eating food brought by other girls. Since I was small I could not understand anything. That day I decided not to tell them any more whose food I had eaten. Whenever they insisted on knowing I would tell them I had eaten the curd rice.

A lady from our neighbourhood, who worked in our school as a cook, prepared the mid-day meal. My mother had told her to keep an eye on me because I had the habit of eating food brought by others. The lady was of our caste. She caught me red-handed one day. She told me I could not eat food brought by others; I could share my food with them but not eat theirs. So, she also became my enemy. I looked at her defiantly, thinking how it mattered to her whose food I ate. 'Why are you giving me that defiant look? I will report to your parents,' she said and promptly came and told my parents.

That night my parents harangued me saying, 'What kind of a child are you? A good person needs only one scolding and a cow needs only one branding.' I was furious with the mid-day meal lady. I stopped talking to her from that day onwards.

Next day my father came with me to the school and told my teacher, 'Take care of this girl. She is disobedient. She is so small but still she has a temper. Give her a bit of advice.' My teacher Saroja Devi was also of my caste. She also advised me like my mother and father and the mid-day meal lady. I thought if I was with girls of our caste no one would scold me, so I decided not to mix with lower caste girls. But there was a great conflict in my mind. Girls of my caste came to school but girls of other caste also came to school. It was difficult to find out who belonged to my caste and who didn't.

I thought, instead of discriminating between my caste and another, it was best not to talk to anyone at all. Then there would be no problem. From that day onwards I stopped talking properly with my friends. When they asked, 'What is the matter? How come you are not talking like before?' I made excuses saying I had a cold or that I was unwell. I withdrew from their group. I did not speak to anyone and remained aloof and quiet. The mid-day meal lady came to my house one day and told my parents, 'Nowadays one can't make out where your daughter is in school.' My parents were ever so happy to hear that.

## **Her Story, My Story Why I am hopeful about gender justice**

### **Droupadi Murmu, President of India**

On Constitution Day last year, I was delivering the valedictory address at the celebrations organised by the Supreme Court of India. Talking of justice, I thought of the under-trial prisoners and then could not resist speaking at length about their plight. I spoke from the heart, and it made an impact. Today, on International Women's Day, I want to share some thoughts with you in the same spirit – straight from the heart.

Right from my childhood days I have remained perplexed about the status of women in society. On one hand, a girl child receives so much love from all around her and is even worshipped on auspicious days. On the other hand, she learns very soon that the possibilities open before her in life are fewer than those available to boys of her age. On one hand, a woman is respected for her innate wisdom, even appreciated as the central figure of the family who takes care of everybody. On the other hand, she has a limited role, if at all, in nearly all significant decisions about the family or even herself.

Over the years, as I stepped out of home, first as a student, then as a teacher and later in social service, I could not help but wonder about such paradoxical attitudes. Sometimes I felt that as individuals, a majority of us recognise men and women as equal. However, at a collective level, the same people impose limits on a half of us. During my lifetime itself, I have seen most individuals progressing towards the notion of equality. At the social level, however, old customs and traditions, like old habits, linger on.

This is the story of all women around the world. Every other human being on earth begins life with a kind of hindrance. In the twenty-first century, when we have achieved unimaginable all-round progress, many nations are yet to have a woman as the head of the state or head of the government. At the other end of the spectrum, unfortunately, there are places in the world where even today women are considered lesser human beings; where even going to school can be a question of life and death for a girl!

This was not always so. In India, there were times when women were decision-makers. Our scriptures and our history talk of women known for their valour, scholarship or administrative skills. Today, again, countless women are of course contributing to the nation-building in their chosen fields. They are heading corporate firms and even serving in the armed forces. The only difference is that they have to prove their worth in two domains – they have to excel in their career and also in their homes. They do not complain but all they expect from society is that it reposes confidence in them.

This leads to a curious situation. We do have a healthy representation of women at the grassroots level in various decision-making structures. But as we go up in the hierarchy, we see fewer and fewer women. This is as true for political bodies as for the bureaucracy, the judiciary and the corporate world. What is noticeable is that even the states with higher Page

3 of 4 literacy rates display the same trend. It shows that education alone does not guarantee financial and political autonomy for women.

Therefore, I firmly believe that the social mindset needs to be changed. The deeply ingrained gender prejudices must be identified and purged to create a peaceful and prosperous society. Conscious efforts have been made to promote social justice and equality. But these steps have not proved adequate to ensure gender representation. In education and jobs, for Example, women lag far behind men more because of social conditioning than any design.

In a number of convocations I have attended in different parts of the country, I have noticed that women, if given a chance, often outperform men in academia. It is this indomitable spirit of Indian women and our society that gives me confidence about India emerging as the torchbearer of gender justice in the world.

It is certainly not the case that one half of humanity has had any headstart by keeping the other half behind. The fact is that this mismatch is hurting the whole of humanity, because the two wheels of its cart are unequal. Not only economic progress, but climate action too would speed up if women are included in decision-making. I am sure that the world will be a lot better place if women are made equal stakeholders in the progress of humanity.

I am, indeed, hopeful that the future is bright. I have seen in my life that people change, attitudes change. That is indeed the story of our race; otherwise we would still be living in caves. The story of women's emancipation has proceeded slowly, often painfully slowly, but it has proceeded only in one direction and has never made a U-turn. That is what gives me confidence to believe, as I have often stated, that the coming Amrit Kaal up to the centenary of India's independence belongs to young women.

What makes me hopeful is the fact that we as a nation began with a sound foundation of gender justice. About a century ago Mahatma Gandhi's campaigns during the freedom struggle encouraged women to cross the threshold and step out into the world. From those days, our society as a whole and women in particular have aspired to build a better future. Prejudices and customs not favourable to women are being done away with either through legislation or through awareness. This seemed to have positive impact as Parliament today has the highest number of women representation. Needless to say, my election as the President of the world's largest democracy is a part of the saga of women's empowerment. I believe the spirit of "innate leadership in motherhood" needs to be invoked to promote gender justice. A slew of government programmes to directly empower women, such as 'Beti Bachao Beti Padhao', are steps in the right direction.

We should also appreciate the fact that societies take time to match step with the best of progressive ideas. But societies are composed of human beings – half of them women – and it is up to us, each of us, to hasten the progress. Thus, today, I wish to urge each of you to commit yourself to one change, in your family, neighbourhood or workplace – any change

that would bring a smile on a girl's face, any change that would improve her chances of moving ahead in life. That is one request, as I said before, straight from the heart.

# Unit 3: The Future of Language – AI, Ethics, and Digital Fluency

## Introduction to Essential AI and Prompting in Language Studies

### The Context of Language Studies in the AI Era

The rapid development of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI), particularly Large Language Models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT (OpenAI), Gemini (Google), Perplexity, and Claude (Anthropic), represents a profound shift in how we interact with, generate, and analyze language. It is a fundamental component of digital and linguistic literacy.

### Foundation Models: Large Language Models (LLMs)

#### 2.1. Defining Large Language Models

LLMs are a class of artificial intelligence built upon a neural network architecture known as the transformer. They are trained on massive datasets of text and code—often trillions of words scraped from the internet, books, and articles—allowing them to internalize the statistical rules, patterns, and nuances of human language at an unprecedented scale. When a user submits a prompt, the model processes the input, assigns mathematical probabilities to potential subsequent words (tokens), and generates the most statistically likely, coherent, and contextually appropriate response.

#### 2.2. Key Players in the Ecosystem

While the underlying technology is similar, the various LLMs available to students offer different strengths and proprietary interfaces:

| LLM Platform       | Primary Focus/Model | Key Characteristics                                                                                                         |
|--------------------|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ChatGPT (OpenAI)   | GPT-3.5, GPT-4      | Pioneer of the current generation; highly versatile for creative and general tasks.                                         |
| Gemini (Google)    | Gemini family       | Deeply integrated with information retrieval; often excels at real-time data analysis and reasoning.                        |
| Claude (Anthropic) | Claude family       | Developed with a focus on safety and "Constitutional AI"; strong performance on long-form text and complex ethical queries. |
| Perplexity         | Various models      | Focused on being an "answer engine"; provides direct, verifiable sources for its generated responses.                       |

### 3. The Art and Science of Prompt Engineering

Prompt engineering is the discipline of crafting inputs (prompts) that steer a Large Language Model toward producing a desired and high-quality output. It transforms the interaction from a simple search query into a collaborative exercise in linguistic design.

### 3.1. Core Principles of Effective Prompting

Scholarly approaches to effective AI interaction emphasize structured input to optimize the statistical prediction process. The MIT Sloan School of Management and others identify four core principles essential for generating reliable and useful AI responses:

#### A. Clarity (Unambiguity)

The instruction must be clear and free from jargon or ambiguity. Avoid compound questions; state the single, central action the model must take.

#### B. Specificity (Detail)

Define the output parameters precisely. This includes specifying the desired length (e.g., "500 words," "three bullet points"), the format (e.g., "a formal email," "a comparative table"), and the topic scope.

#### C. Context (Background)

Provide the LLM with relevant background information to anchor its response. This can include defining terms, specifying a time period, or supplying text for analysis.

#### D. Role Assignment (Persona)

Asking the model to assume a persona or role conditions its tone, vocabulary, and expertise. This is crucial in language studies, where tone and audience are paramount (e.g., "Act as a professional copy editor," or "Adopt the tone of a Victorian-era critic").

### 3.2. Practical Prompting Strategies

| Strategy                    | Description                                                                              | Example for Daily English Use                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Instructional Prompt</b> | A direct command specifying the action and the expected output.                          | <i>"Draft a concise email to my professor asking for an extension on the essay. The tone must be polite and professional."</i>      |
| <b>Zero-Shot Prompting</b>  | Providing instructions without an example. Assumes the model inherently knows the task.  | <i>"Analyze the rhetorical devices used in the opening paragraph of this article."</i>                                              |
| <b>Few-Shot Prompting</b>   | Providing one or more examples of the desired input-output format, enabling the model to | <i>"Here are two examples of meeting minutes: [Example 1]; [Example 2]. Now, draft minutes for the following audio transcript."</i> |

| Strategy                      | Description                                                                                                                             | Example for Daily English Use                                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                               | mimic the required style or structure.                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Chain-of-Thought (CoT)</b> | Asking the model to "think aloud" or show its reasoning before providing the final answer (e.g., by adding "Explain your steps first"). | <i>"I need to find the main argument of this op-ed. First, identify the thesis statement, then list the three supporting claims, and finally, summarize the argument in one sentence."</i> |

## 4. LLMs in Daily English Language Application

LLMs are powerful tools for developing proficiency in daily English language communication, critical analysis, and stylistic refinement.

### 4.1. Enhancing Clarity and Conciseness

LLMs serve as advanced editing and revision partners. By using highly specific instructional prompts, one can refine their writing for different purposes:

- **Prompt Example:** *"Review the following draft of my cover letter. Act as a job recruiter. Highlight five instances where the language is too passive and rewrite those sentences using strong, active verbs."*

This practice moves beyond simple grammar checking, turning the AI into a pedagogical tool that helps us to identify and correct our own stylistic weaknesses.

### 4.2. Contextual Nuance and Style Mimicry

The core task of language studies involves recognizing and replicating distinct linguistic registers and tones. LLMs can be prompted to perform complex stylistic transformations:

- **Prompt Example:** *"Take this short, informal text message I wrote and rewrite it entirely for two different audiences: 1) as a formal business memo, and 2) as a friendly but witty blog post. Maintain the core message but change the vocabulary, sentence structure, and tone for each version."*

This exercise in register shifting demonstrates the model's capacity to understand pragmatic context and aids students in mastering audience-appropriate communication.

### 4.3. Analysis of Text and Rhetoric

For academic reading and preparation, LLMs can accelerate comprehension and critical analysis when used judiciously:

- **Prompt Example (using CoT):** *"I am analyzing a speech for a course. First, identify the speaker's main intended emotional appeal (pathos). Second, extract three phrases*



*that exemplify this appeal. Finally, evaluate the effectiveness of the pathos based on the historical context."*

This approach utilizes the LLM for structured extraction and initial analysis, freeing the student to focus on the higher-order task of critical evaluation.

## 5. Academic Integrity and Ethical Engagement

The integration of LLMs into higher education necessitates a rigorous commitment to ethical practices.

### 5.1. The Imperative of Attribution and Originality

The single greatest ethical challenge is the potential for plagiarism (Frontiers, 2024). Submitting text generated entirely by an LLM as one's own work undermines the educational purpose of assignments.

**Best Practice:** AI tools must be treated as advanced computational aids—like calculators or spell checkers—not as surrogate authors. Clear institutional guidelines will mandate:

1. **Citation:** Any substantial use of LLM-generated content (e.g., initial drafts, summaries, brainstormed outlines) must be explicitly acknowledged and cited according to the specific formatting guidelines (e.g., MLA, APA).
2. **Originality:** The student remains responsible for the final output, including the synthesis, critical evaluation, and original thought, which the LLM cannot replicate (PNAS, 2025).

### 5.2. Mitigating Hallucination and Bias

LLMs are prone to hallucination, the phenomenon of generating confident-sounding but factually incorrect or fabricated information, including bogus citations (Open Universities Australia, 2023).

- **Critical Evaluation:** Students must never blindly trust an LLM's response. Every piece of information, particularly factual claims, must be **cross-referenced and verified** using authoritative primary and secondary sources.
- **Bias Awareness:** LLMs are trained on historical data that often contains societal, political, or demographic biases (PNAS, 2025). When using LLMs for tasks like translating cultural concepts or analyzing social issues, students must critically interrogate the response to identify and challenge any potential reinforcement of harmful stereotypes or skewing of viewpoints.

The introduction of LLMs marks an undeniable and permanent advancement in the field of language technology. For degree students, the path to mastery lies in embracing these tools not as shortcuts, but as sophisticated instruments for linguistic augmentation and analysis. By mastering the core principles of prompt engineering (Clarity, Specificity, Context, and Role Assignment) and operating within a framework of rigorous academic ethics, students can leverage the power of ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Claude, and their successors to become

more effective, critical, and nuanced communicators in the contemporary English language. The ultimate goal is to shift from being passive recipients of AI output to becoming active, critical prompt engineers shaping the language models' capabilities for personal and academic growth.

## **All Watched Over By Machines Of Loving Grace**

**Richard Brautigan**

I like to think (and  
the sooner the better!)  
of a cybernetic meadow  
where mammals and computers  
live together in mutually  
programming harmony  
like pure water  
touching clear sky.

I like to think  
(right now, please!)  
of a cybernetic forest  
filled with pines and electronics  
where deer stroll peacefully  
past computers  
as if they were flowers  
with spinning blossoms.

I like to think  
(it has to be!)  
of a cybernetic ecology  
where we are free of our labors  
and joined back to nature,  
returned to our mammal  
brothers and sisters,  
and all watched over  
by machines of loving grace.

**Be Polite to ChatGPT and Siri! - A Beginner's Guide to AI.**

**<https://pods.ee/e/863477>**

## The Future of Writing Is a Lot Like Hip-Hop (Excerpts)

**A new kind of literary curation will be the defining skill for the next era of human creativity.**

**Stephen Marche**

Creative artificial intelligence provokes a strange mixture of contempt and dread. People say things such as “AI art is garbage” and “It’s plagiarism,” but also “AI art is going to destroy creativity itself.” These reactions are contradictory, but nobody seems to notice. AI is the bogeyman in the shadows: the obscurity, more than anything the monster has actually perpetrated, is the source of loathing and despair.

Consider the ongoing feud between the Writers Guild of America and the Alliance of Motion Picture and Television Producers. The writers are on strike, arguing, among other things, that studios should not be able to use AI tools to replace their labor. “It’s important to note that AI software does not create anything. It generates a regurgitation of what it’s fed,” the WGA has claimed. “Plagiarism is a feature of the AI process.” The AMPTP, for its part, has offered “annual meetings to discuss advancements in technology.” Neither side knows exactly what it’s talking about, but they feel they have to fight about it anyway.

So little of how we talk about AI actually comes from the experience of using it. Almost every essay or op-ed you read follows the same trajectory: I used ChatGPT to do a thing, and from that thing, I can predict catastrophic X or industry-altering Y. Like the camera, the full consequences of this technology will be worked out over a great deal of time by a great number of talents responding to a great number of developments. But at the time of writing, almost all the conversation surrounding generative AI is imaginary, rooted not in the use of the tool but in extrapolated Visions.

So when Jacob Weisberg, the CEO of Pushkin Industries, called me one Friday in January and asked if I wanted to write an AI-generated novel, I said yes immediately. To be more precise, he asked if I wanted to be the producer of an AI that would “write” a novel. It was the exact kind of opportunity to dive headfirst into a practical extended application of the new technology that I’d been looking for. The experience has been, in equal measures, phantasmagoric and grounding.

My conclusion is informed but unsatisfying. Creative AI is going to change everything. It’s also going to change nothing.

Using AI to write fiction is not unfamiliar to me. I’ve been using artificial intelligence to write short stories since 2017, when I published an early “algostory” in *Wired*; I also produced a 17 percent computer-generated horror story for the *Los Angeles Review of Books* called “being on the Phone” in 2021, and the short “Autotuned Love Story,” built out of stylistic bots, for *Lithub* a year later. But these experiments were mostly lyrical. What Weisberg was proposing was entirely different: The novel would have to be 95 percent computer-generated, relatively short (about 25,000 words), and of excellent quality (there would be no point in creating yet another

unimaginative mass of GPT text; readers could just do that themselves).

Because I was making derivative art, I would go all the way, run into the limitations, into the derivative: The plot would be a murder mystery about a writer killed by tech that is supposedly targeting writers. I called it *Death of an Author*. I worked out the plot during a long skate with my daughter and a walk with my son (better techniques than any machine could offer), and began taking copious notes.

The experiment would attempt to be compulsively readable, a page-turner. At first, I tried to get the machines to write like my favorite, Jim Thompson, the dime-store Dostoevsky. It couldn't come close: The subterfuge of Thompson's writing, a mille-feuille of irony and horror with subtle and variable significance, was too complex for me to articulate to the machine. Its failure is probably due to my own weakness rather than the limitations of the AI. Raymond Chandler, however, I had better results with. I sort of know what Raymond Chandler is doing and could explain it, I thought, to a machine: driving, electric, forceful, active prose with flashes of bright Beauty.

My process mostly involved the use of ChatGPT—I found very little difference between the free service and the paid one that utilizes the more advanced GPT-4 model—and Sudowrite, a GPT-based, stochastic writing instrument. I would give ChatGPT instructions such as “Write an article in the style of the *Toronto Star* containing the following information: Peggy Firmin was a Canadian writer who was murdered on a bridge on the Leslie Street Spit on August 14 with no witnesses.” Then I'd paste the output into Sudowrite, which gives you a series of AI-assisted options to customize text: You can expand, shorten, rephrase, and “customize” a selection. For Example, you can tell Sudowrite to “make it more active” or “make it more conversational,” which I did with almost every passage in *Death of an Author*. But you can also give it a prompt such as “Make it more like Hemingway.”

Quite quickly, I figured out that if you want an AI to imitate Raymond Chandler, the last thing you should do is ask it to write like Raymond Chandler. That produces a tepid, banal rip-off: “She lay there on the bridge, motionless as the traffic flowed by, and I knew that Peggy Firmin had taken her last breath in this city of lost souls.” Cheesy. I had a lot more success asking ChatGPT to write something about a murder scene in the style of Chinese nature poetry and then having Sudowrite make it active, then make it conversational, and then convert it to the style of Ernest Hemingway. Raymond Chandler, after all, was not trying to write like Raymond Chandler.

I wanted the novel to have some good lines too. Raymond Chandler books chug along at a blistering pace and then stop you with lines like “It was a blonde. A blonde to make a bishop kick a hole through a stained glass window.” I didn't find ChatGPT particularly good at this kind of richness. So I used Cohere, an AI platform that I've experimented with before. This program allowed me to create prompts and then develop them through iteration: I would make a request such as “Write a simile about the smell of coffee,” feed it other descriptions of the smell of coffee, and then refresh the screen until it provided a description I liked—in this case, “e smell of coffee was like fog burning off a field.” The best lines in the novel are all from Cohere.

Given the experimental nature of the project, I will be frank about the results. *Death of an Author*, I believe, is compulsively readable, with some beautiful moments; Laura Miller called it “pretty good!” and Dwight Garner went with “halfway readable.” If you look at it closely, you might sense that it is machine-written, but I feel confident, at any rate, asserting that it is much, much better than the literary industrial product of the many AI-generated titles on Amazon right now.

If that is the case—you’ll have to read the book to know yourself—then I’d suggest there are three basic reasons. First, I had an elaborate plan for the book. Second, I have deep familiarity with the technology and access to some technologies that others don’t, so I was more aware of the limitations and the possibilities. Finally, and by far most important, I know what good writing looks like. I know who Sudowrite should imitate (and can articulate why), and I know what a polished sentence and a truly finished paragraph are. You need more understanding of literary style, not less. The closest analogue to this process is hip-hop. To make hip-hop, you don’t need to know how to play the drums, but you do need to be able to reference the entire history of beats and hooks. Every producer becomes an archive; the greater their knowledge and the more coherent their understanding, the better the resulting work. The creator of meaningful literary AI art will be, in effect, a literary curator.

The traditional values of creative composition were entirely alive during my process. That should come as no surprise. The transition from painting to photography required a complete reevaluation of the nature of visual creativity, but the value of understanding form and color, of framing, of the ability to recognize the transience of emotion across a face or a landscape—the need to understand the materials of production and the power of your subjects—stayed. None of that is going away. None of it will ever go away.

If you take a hammer and hit yourself over the head with it, the hammer did not give you a headache. If you make bad art with a new tool, you just haven’t figured out how to use the tool yet. Also, tools are just tools: Everyone has access to a thesaurus; some people have richer vocabularies than others nevertheless. Linguistic AI is no messiah, and it is no anti-Christ. It is a fundamentally mysterious tool whose confounding inabilities will be as surprising as its wondrous capabilities.

There was one question that I kept asking myself while I was writing *Death of an Author*: “Who’s making this?” At first, I wanted to publish the book under my own name. You do not say that a Hasselblad camera took a photograph generated by Gered Mankowitz—you say that Gered Mankowitz used a Hasselblad to take a photograph. But that analogy is imprecise. To say “Stephen Marche wrote *Death of an Author*” would be inaccurate as a matter of fact. I am the book’s author, legally, but a machine wrote it based on my instructions. We went back and forth on the authorship question. Eventually, I asked ChatGPT to write a pseudonym for a collaboration between myself and transformer-based artificial intelligence. It came up with Aidan Marchine—a fusion of Marche and machine.

I wish I’d thought of it myself.

## There Will Come Soft Rains Ray Bradbury

In the living room the voice-clock sang, *Tick-tock, seven o'clock, time to get up, time to get up, seven o'clock!* as if it were afraid that nobody would. The morning house lay empty. The clock ticked on, repeating and repeating its sounds into the emptiness. *Seven-nine, breakfast time, seven-nine!*

In the kitchen the breakfast stove gave a hissing sigh and ejected from its warm interior eight pieces of perfectly browned toast, eight eggs sunny side up, sixteen slices of bacon, two coffees, and two cool glasses of milk

*"Today is August 4, 2026,"* said a second voice from the kitchen ceiling, *"in the city of Allendale, California."* It repeated the date three times for memory's sake. *"Today is Mr. Featherstone's birthday. Today is the anniversary of Tilita's marriage. Insurance is payable, as are the water, gas, and light bills."*

Somewhere in the walls, relays clicked, memory tapes glided under electric eyes.

*Eight-one, tick-tock, eight-one o'clock, off to school, off to work, run, run, eight-one!* But no doors slammed, no carpets took the soft tread of rubber heels. It was raining outside. The weather box on the front door sang quietly: *"Rain, rain, go away; umbrellas, raincoats for today. .."* And the rain tapped on the empty house, echoing

Outside, the garage chimed and lifted its door to reveal the waiting car. After a long wait the door swung down again

At eight-thirty the eggs were shrivelled and the toast was like stone. An aluminium wedge scraped them into the sink, where hot water whirled them down a metal throat which digested and flushed them away to the distant sea. The dirty dishes were dropped into a hot washer and emerged twinkling dry.

*Nine-fifteen,* sang the clock, *time to clean*

Out of warrens in the wall, tiny robot mice darted. The rooms were a crawl with the small cleaning animals, all rubber and metal. They thudded against chairs, whirling their moustached runners, kneading the rug nap, sucking gently at hidden dust. Then, like mysterious invaders, they popped into their burrows. Their pink electric eyes faded. The house was clean.

Ten o'clock. The sun came out from behind the rain. The house stood alone in a city of rubble and ashes. This was the one house left standing. At night the ruined city gave off a radioactive glow which could be seen for miles.

Ten-fifteen. The garden sprinklers whirled up in golden founts, filling the soft morning air with scatterings of brightness. The water pelted window panes, running down the charred west side where the house had been burned, evenly free of its white paint. The entire west face of the house was black, save for five places. Here the silhouette in paint of a man mowing a lawn. Here, as in a photograph, a woman bent to pick flowers. Still farther over, their images burned on wood in one titanic instant, a small boy, hands flung into the air; higher up, the image of a thrown ball, and opposite him a girl, hands raised to catch a ball which never came down. The five spots of paint - the man, the woman, the children, the ball - remained. The rest was a thin charcoaled layer.

The gentle sprinkler rain filled the garden with falling light.

Until this day, how well the house had kept its peace. How carefully it had inquired, "Who goes there? What's the password?" and, getting no answer from lonely foxes and whining cats, it had shut up its windows and drawn shades in an old-maidenly preoccupation with self-protection which bordered on a mechanical paranoia.

It quivered at each sound, the house did. If a sparrow brushed a window, the shade snapped up. The bird, startled, flew off! No, not even a bird must touch the house!

Twelve noon.

A dog whined, shivering, on the front porch.

The front door recognized the dog voice and opened. The dog, once huge and fleshy, but now gone to bone and covered with sores, moved in and through the house, tracking mud. Behind it whirled angry mice, angry at having to pick up mud, angry at inconvenience.

For not a leaf fragment blew under the door but what the wall panels flipped open and the copper scrap rats flashed swiftly out. The offending dust, hair, or paper, seized in miniature steel jaws, was raced back to the burrows. There, down tubes which fed into the cellar, it was dropped into the sighing vent of an incinerator which sat like evil Baal in a dark corner. The dog ran upstairs, hysterically yelping to each door, at last realizing, as the house realized, that only silence was here.

It sniffed the air and scratched the kitchen door. Behind the door, the stove was making pancakes which filled the house with a rich baked odour and the scent of maple syrup.

The dog frothed at the mouth, lying at the door, sniffing, its eyes turned to fire. It ran wildly in circles, biting at its tail, spun in a frenzy, and died. It lay in the parlor for an hour.

Two o'clock, sang a voice.

Delicately sensing decay at last, the regiments of mice hummed out as softly as blown gray leaves in an electrical wind.

Two-fifteen.

The dog was gone.

In the cellar, the incinerator glowed suddenly and a whirl of sparks leaped up the chimney.

Two thirty-five.



Bridge tables sprouted from patio walls. Playing cards fluttered onto pads in a shower of pips. Martinis manifested on an oaken bench with egg-salad sandwiches. Music played.

But the tables were silent and the cards untouched.

At four o'clock the tables folded like great butterflies back through the paneled walls.

Four-thirty.

The nursery walls glowed.

Animals took shape: yellow giraffes, blue lions, pink antelopes, lilac panthers cavorting in crystal substance. The walls were glass. They looked out upon color and fantasy. Hidden films clocked through well-oiled sprockets, and the walls lived. The nursery floor was woven to resemble a crisp, cereal meadow. Over this ran aluminum roaches and iron crickets, and in the hot still air butterflies of delicate red tissue wavered among the sharp aroma of animal spoors! There was the sound like a great matted yellow hive of bees within a dark bellows, the lazy bumble of a purring lion. And there was the patter of okapi feet and the murmur of a fresh jungle rain, like other hoofs, falling upon the summer-starched grass. Now the walls dissolved into distances of parched grass, mile on mile, and warm endless sky. The animals drew away into thorn brakes and water holes. It was the children's hour.

Five o'clock. The bath filled with clear hot water.

Six, seven, eight o'clock. The dinner dishes manipulated like magic tricks, and in the study a click.

In the metal stand opposite the hearth where a fire now blazed up warmly, a cigar popped out, half an inch of soft gray ash on it, smoking, waiting.

Nine o'clock. The beds warmed their hidden circuits, for nights were cool here.

Nine-five. A voice spoke from the study ceiling: "*Mrs. McClellan, which poem would you like this evening?*" The house was silent.

The voice said at last, "*Since you express no preference, I shall select a poem at random.*" Quiet music rose to back the voice. "*Sara Teasdale. As I recall, your favourite...*

*There will come soft rains and the smell of the ground,  
And swallows circling with their shimmering sound;*

*And frogs in the pools singing at night,  
And wild plum trees in tremulous white;*

*Robins will wear their feathery fire,*

*Whistling their whims on a low fence-wire;*

*And not one will know of the war, not one  
Will care at last when it is done.*

*Not one would mind, neither bird nor tree,  
If mankind perished utterly;*

*And Spring herself, when she woke at dawn  
Would scarcely know that we were gone."*

The fire burned on the stone hearth and the cigar fell away into a mound of quiet ash on its tray. The empty chairs faced each other between the silent walls, and the music played.

At ten o'clock the house began to die.

The wind blew. A falling tree bough crashed through the kitchen window. Cleaning solvent, bottled, shattered over the stove. The room was ablaze in an instant!

"Fire!" screamed a voice. The house lights flashed, water pumps shot water from the ceilings. But the solvent spread on the linoleum, licking, eating, under the kitchen door, while the voices took it up in chorus: "Fire, fire, fire!"

The house tried to save itself. Doors sprang tightly shut, but the windows were broken by the heat and the wind blew and sucked upon the fire.

The house gave ground as the fire in ten billion angry sparks moved with flaming ease from room to room and then up the stairs. While scurrying water rats squeaked from the walls, pistoled their water, and ran for more.

And the wall sprays let down showers of mechanical rain.

But too late. Somewhere, sighing, a pump shrugged to a stop. The quenching rain ceased. The reserve water supply which had filled baths and washed dishes for many quiet days was gone.

The fire crackled up the stairs. It fed upon Picassos and Matisses in the upper halls, like delicacies, baking off the oily flesh, tenderly crisping the canvases into black shavings.

Now the fire lay in beds, stood in windows, changed the colors of drapes!

And then, reinforcements. From attic trapdoors, blind robot faces peered down with faucet mouths gushing green chemical.

The fire backed off, as even an elephant must at the sight of a dead snake.

Now there were twenty snakes whipping over the floor, killing the fire with a clear cold venom of green froth.

But the fire was clever. It had sent flame outside the house, up through the attic to the pumps there.

An explosion! The attic brain which directed the pumps was shattered into bronze shrapnel on the beams.

The fire rushed back into every closet and felt of the clothes hung there.

The house shuddered, oak bone on bone, its bared skeleton cringing from the heat, its wire, its nerves revealed as if a surgeon had torn the skin off to let the red veins and capillaries

quiver in the scalded air. Help, help! Fire! Run, run! Heat snapped mirrors like the first brittle winter ice. And the voices wailed. Fire, fire, run, run, like a tragic nursery rhyme, a dozen voices, high, low, like children dying in a forest, alone, alone. And the voices fading as the wires popped their sheathings like hot chestnuts. One, two, three, four, five voices died.

In the nursery the jungle burned. Blue lions roared, purple giraffes bounded off. The panthers ran in circles, changing color, and ten million animals, running before the fire, vanished off toward a distant steaming river.... Ten more voices died.

In the last instant under the fire avalanche, other choruses, oblivious, could be heard announcing the time, cutting the lawn by remote-control mower, or setting an umbrella frantically out and in, the slamming and opening front door, a thousand things happening, like a clock shop when each clock strikes the hour insanely before or after the other, a scene of maniac confusion, yet unity; singing, screaming, a few last cleaning mice darting bravely out to carry the horrid ashes away! And one voice, with sublime disregard for the situation, read poetry aloud in the fiery study, until all the film spools burned, until all the wires withered and the circuits cracked.

The fire burst the house and let it slam flat down, puffing out skirts of spark and smoke. In the kitchen, an instant before the rain of fire and timber, the stove could be seen making breakfasts at a psychopathic rate, ten dozen eggs, six loaves of toast, twenty dozen bacon strips, which, eaten by fire, started the stove working again, hysterically hissing!

The crash. The attic smashing into kitchen and parlour. The parlour into cellar, cellar into sub-cellar. Deep freeze, armchair, film tapes, circuits, beds, and all like skeletons thrown in a cluttered mound deep under.

Smoke and silence. A great quantity of smoke.

Dawn showed faintly in the east.

Among the ruins, one wall stood alone. Within the wall, a last voice said, over and over again and again, even as the sun rose to shine upon the heaped rubble and steam: *"Today is August 5, 2026, today is August 5, 2026, today is..."*